

FABLE

ENGINE SCHEMA · VERSION 4

The irreducible mechanical specification, fused with the design philosophy it enforces. Every surface has one job; every promise has a mechanical enforcement point. Examples, teaching, and calibration live in the Starter Kit — this document is the spec.

∞ Design Claim

FABLE models **capable people changing dangerous situations in a causal world under pressure**. The drama comes from cost, uncertainty, consequence, and world motion — never from incompetence or random failure. One act is at once a **strategic move** and an **act of character**.

The engine cares about six things: **Intent** (what someone tries to make true), **Uncertainty** (whether dice are still needed), **Cost** (what sour outcomes demand), **Effect** (how much success changes), **Truth** (what persists), and **Time** (what advances while people act).

Central thesis. Preparation changes the *shape* of risk, not its existence. It can remove **reducible** uncertainty, but never **irreducible** uncertainty unless the fiction removes that uncertainty's source.

Interiority. Dice change circumstances, costs, pressures, relationships, reputations, wounds, and facts. Dice never decide what a player character feels, believes, wants, or becomes inside.

oI Promises & Enforcement

Every philosophical promise has a mechanical enforcement point; every surface exists to keep a promise. A rule that serves no promise is rejected; a promise with no enforcement is unfinished.

PROMISE	ENFORCED BY	FAILURE MODE IT PREVENTS
Strategy matters	Ledger · Truths · Preparation · Top Exit	cleverness paying only at GM whim
Strategy is not deterministic	Exit Check · Simple/Complex obstacles · Clocks · Fronts	the scene solved before it begins
Competence is reliable	the 3d6 curve · no roll produces nothing	drama-by-whiffing
Danger is not difficulty	the TN / Exposure split	inflating TN to express threat
Tension survives competence	Exposure · Effect limits · Clocks · Fronts · Seams	a tensionless clean-success treadmill
Consequences persist	Truths · Scars · clocks landing Truths	a world that forgets
Drama is mechanical, not bait	Drive · Question · Bonds · compels · Edge	roleplay-for-XP
The interior is sovereign	Held Truths · the interiority invariant	dice dictating feelings
Time is the spine	Clocks · preparation costs time · world motion · maintained Truths	pressure that never moves; advantages that never erode
One engine, no bloat	the Mode rule · the surface test	subsystem growth

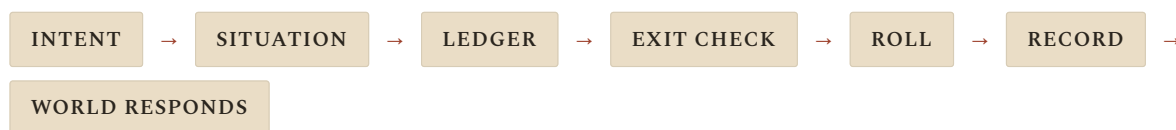
02 Mechanical Surfaces

Each surface has exactly one job.

SURFACE	TERM	JOB
Task difficulty	TN	how hard the task is to perform
Consequence severity	Exposure	how bad sour results are
Amount achieved	Effect	how much success accomplishes
Risk/effect swap	Trade	a voluntary pre-roll exchange of Exposure for Effect
Advantage conversion	Ledger	turns fictional advantage into stakes or permission
No-roll impossibility	Bottom Exit	the approach cannot work
No-roll certainty	Top Exit	no live uncertainty remains
Persistent reality	Truth	something true until changed
Time pressure	Clock	a countdown toward a Truth
World pressure	Front	an active force that owns clocks
Personal resource	Edge	a capped resource for pressing advantage
Short-term pressure	Stress	recoverable pressure and harm
Lasting consequence	Scar	persistent harm, mark, or loss

Invariant. No rule may use one surface to do another surface's job.

03 Core Loop



1. **Intent** — state what the acting character wants to make true.
2. **Situation** — establish position, known Truths, active clocks, opposition, tools, and stakes.
3. **Ledger** — claimed advantages convert to Position, Leverage, Access, or Seam.
4. **Exit Check** — decide Bottom Exit, Top Exit, or Live Roll.
5. **Roll** — if uncertainty remains, roll 3d6 + Skill vs TN.
6. **Record** — write Stress, Scars, Truths, clock ticks, and changed circumstances.
7. **World Responds** — Fronts and consequences advance through costs, setbacks, clocks, and Truths.

04 Characters & Skills

A character is: **Concept** · **Skills** · **Traits** · **Bonds** · **Drive** · **Question** · **Gear** · **Stress** · **Scars** · **Edge**.

Skills are rated **0–4**: 0 untrained · 1 capable · 2 professional · 3 expert · 4 master. At creation, spend **12 points**, maximum **3** in any skill. There are no attributes beneath skills; the skill follows the fictional approach.

Untrained. Using Skill 0 for professional work or harder raises **Exposure by 1**. The task is no harder; the character is less protected from consequence.

05 The Roll

Roll only when the intent matters, the outcome is genuinely uncertain, the approach is possible, and the result would change the situation.

Roll = 3d6 + Skill Margin = Roll - TN		
+3 or more	Triumph	intent succeeds; Effect steps up once; gain 1 Edge
0 to +2	Success	intent succeeds cleanly at stated Effect
-1 to -2	Cost	intent succeeds at stated Effect, and a cost lands at stated Exposure
-3 or less	Setback	intent does not land, and the situation turns against the actor at stated Exposure

No roll produces "nothing happens."

The Anchor. Before adjusting, assume **TN 10 · Exposure 1 · Effect Standard**. Change only what the fiction makes different.

No empty rolls. Because success is reliable, the engine supplies no tension through failure. A roll with **no live clock and no meaningful Exposure** changes nothing worth rolling — resolve it as a **Top Exit**. Tension lives in cost, time, and consequence; if none is at stake, do not roll.

No post-roll renegotiation. TN, Exposure, Effect, Skill, and stakes are fixed before the roll.

06 TN

TN measures the task, not the danger.

TN	TASK
8	simple trained work
10	standard professional work
12	genuinely challenging work
13	hard specialist work
14	extreme, reputation-making work

Contested TN = 10 + opposing Skill, used when a capable opponent actively contests the intent.

Invariant. Danger never increases TN. Danger changes Exposure.

07 Exposure

Exposure measures the severity of sour results (range 0-2; modules may add higher tiers).

EXPOSURE	COST	SETBACK
0	minor, recoverable	the chance slips; no direct Scar; a retry raises Exposure
1	real	serious escalation or harm
2	severe	severe turn; a Scar only via a live Seam or Stress overflow

COST REGISTERS

When a Cost or Setback lands, pick the one the fiction supports:

REGISTER	MEANING
Harm	mark Stress
Time	tick a Clock
Ground	lose footing, distance, control, access, cover, or tempo
Trace	leave evidence, witnesses, suspicion, or attention
Resource	spend, damage, or lose gear or supply
Relational	strain a bond, favor, reputation, trust, or obligation

Harm guideline: Exposure 0 → 1 Stress · Exposure 1 → 2-3 Stress · Exposure 2 → 4-5 Stress, or a Scar via a live Seam or overflow.

08 Effect

Effect measures how much success accomplishes.

EFFECT	DELIVERS
Limited	part of the intent: narrower, weaker, slower, conditional, or needing another step
Standard	the intent as stated
Great	the intent plus reach: faster, quieter, broader, cleaner, more durable
Spectacular	beyond normal scope; only from a Triumph when Effect was already Great

Effect cannot drop below Limited. Declared Effect caps at Great; Spectacular is Triumph overflow.

09 Trade

Before rolling, the actor may choose one Trade.

TRADE	EFFECT	EXPOSURE
Aggressive	+1 step	+1
Measured	—	—
Guarded	–1 step	–1

Both sides must land: Aggressive is unavailable if Exposure can't worsen; Guarded if Effect would fall below Limited. Trade never changes TN and is locked before the roll.

10 Ledger

The Ledger converts fictional advantage into mechanical permission or stakes.

CATEGORY	ADVANTAGE MAKES YOU...	IT PAYS
Position	safer	reduce Exposure by 1
Leverage	stronger	increase Effect by 1
Access	able	a Bottom Exit becomes a Live Roll
Seam	able to end it	terminal consequence becomes possible

Rules. One source pays one category per roll; one roll claims one primary payout unless a rule says otherwise. The Ledger never changes TN and never creates Top Exit. Information *reveals* opportunities; action *claims* them. Baseline fiction is not a payout — a source must be created, seized, timed, earned, or established to pay.

II Exit Check

Before rolling, decide whether dice exist.

STATE	MEANING	RESULT
Bottom Exit	the approach cannot work	no roll; change approach or find Access
Top Exit	no live uncertainty remains	no roll; narrate and move on
Live Roll	uncertainty matters	roll

Simple obstacles hold only known, reducible uncertainty; removing it in the fiction reaches Top Exit. **Complex obstacles** hold irreducible uncertainty — hidden information, chance, adaptive opposition, or volatility — and cannot reach Top Exit until that source is removed or neutralized in the fiction.

Learning. If the intent is to discover the unknown, the unknown *is* the live uncertainty. Learning rolls never reach Top Exit unless the answer is already known. Preparation can make learning safer, narrower, or stronger — never certain.

No-stakes obstacles are Top Exits. An obstacle with no irreducible uncertainty *and* no live clock or Exposure is solved — narrate it. (See §5, No empty rolls.)

A Truth is a persistent fact of the game world — world state, location, relationship, reputation, injury, debt, promise, resource, belief, faction state, condition, or status. Truths persist until changed by play and are not consumed by use.

TYPE	AUTHORSHIP	USE
Fact	Open	a world truth anyone may claim
Bond	Held	a relationship, belief, duty, reputation, Drive, or Question belonging to a character
Trait	Held, charged	a double-edged self-truth invoked through Edge
Scar	Open, about a character	lasting Wound, Mark, or Loss

A Truth informs the **baseline** of every action it touches, but pays a **Ledger** step only where it *changes* that baseline. Open Truths may be claimed by anyone; Held Truths may be pressured or compelled by the world, but only the owning player may rewrite them.

STANDING AND MAINTAINED

Most Truths are **standing**: they persist until changed by play. Some are **maintained**: true *now*, but the kind of thing the world erodes — suppression, a distraction, a held door, a sustained effect, a cover that is holding, ground seized but not secured. A maintained Truth **lapses on the next world-motion unless renewed**; when something actively works to undo it, give it a **recovery clock** (§16) the opposition ticks toward its end. A maintained Truth informs baseline and pays the Ledger **only while it lasts** — which is what makes setup-and-exploit a race rather than a guarantee.

Interiority. Dice may pressure a character's situation, relationships, resources, reputation, or body. Dice never rewrite a player character's inner beliefs or feelings.

13 Edge

Edge is a capped personal resource. **Cap** = 3.

GAIN 1 EDGE WHEN YOU

- roll a **Triumph**;
- **accept a compel** (the world's complication on one of your Truths — *reactive* expression); or
- **act on a Drive, Question, Bond, or Held Truth at a real cost** to your position, safety, resources, relationship, or opportunity (*proactive* expression).

The cost gates the proactive trigger: you cannot gain Edge by expression alone, only by paying for it. (See §23, expression invariant.)

SPEND EDGE

SPEND	COST	TIMING	EFFECT
Lean	1	before roll	invoke a relevant Trait/Bond/Truth: reduce Exposure by 1
Lean	1	after roll	invoke a relevant Trait/Bond/Truth: step the result up one band
Push	1 + 2 Stress	after roll	step the result up one band with no relevant Truth
Shield	1	when an ally takes Harm	take the incoming Stress or Scar route yourself, if fiction allows

Rules. A roll may be stepped up **at most once** by Edge. Edge never changes TN and never creates Top Exit. A band reached by spending Edge generates no Edge. A spend that would do nothing is not spent. Pre-roll Lean cannot reduce Exposure below 0.

Invariant. Edge moves results in band-space (Setback → Cost → Success → Triumph), never by modifying the die total. It is the only resource that may improve a result after the roll, and it cannot snowball.

14 Stress & Scars

Stress is short-term pressure of any kind — injury, exhaustion, fear, social pressure, backlash, overextension. **Track** = 6 boxes. A genuine breather clears Stress (and ticks every Clock whose domain the character remains inside).

Stress is pressure *toward a breaking point*. Its mechanical result is always **external or situational** — a Mark, a forced exit, a lost position. The player narrates what it feels like inside.

Scars are lasting Truths about a character. **Slots** = 3. At 3 Scars the character is **Broken**: out of the scene in a way fiction and tone define.

SCAR	MEANING
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Wound	lasting bodily harm
Mark	lasting reputational, legal, social, or psychological pressure made external
Loss	lasting loss of gear, ally, tie, office, standing, or access

Scars are **situational** — never a global penalty. A Scar bites where relevant: worse Exposure, reduced Effect, a compelled Truth, a Seam for others, Access blocked or opened, or a clock trigger.

Scar Route Invariant. A Scar lands only through **Stress overflow** or **a live Seam exploited by a terminal consequence**. There is no third route. On overflow: take exactly **1 Scar**, then clear Stress. No single event cascades into multiple Scars unless a module allows it.

15 Seam & Terminal Consequence

A **Seam** is an established vulnerability that makes a lasting, decisive, or terminal consequence possible. A Seam does not grant success; it changes what success can *accomplish*.

INTENT	MEANING	EXAMPLES
Situational	changes circumstances	disarm, delay, expose, get past, separate, corner, reveal
Terminal	attempts lasting resolution	kill, cripple, ruin, depose, destroy, permanently expose, end

A terminal intent against a significant target requires a **live Seam**. Without one, a successful terminal intent resolves as situational: deal Stress, create a Truth, improve position, expose a future Seam, tick a defeat clock, or reduce options.

A Seam may be **created, discovered, seized, or exploited**, and may come from a prior Truth, a Scar, surprise, isolation, a named weakness, a debt, a legal vulnerability, a ritual anchor, a true name, a broken formation, or a clock reaching a threshold.

16 Clocks

A Clock tracks pressure accumulating toward a Truth.

SIZE	USE
4	immediate pressure
6	a staged threat or project
8	slow, campaign-scale pressure

When a Clock fills, a Truth lands. Clocks tick when a Cost or Setback advances them, a loud action draws attention, a Front moves, characters take a breather or complete a Prep Round inside the domain, or an active threat is ignored in conflict — and as **time passes, but only when the domain's time meaningfully advances** (not every scene ticks every clock).

A **recovery clock** is the opposition's countdown toward undoing a **maintained Truth** (§12); when it fills, that Truth lapses. Use one only when something actively works to undo the Truth — otherwise a maintained Truth simply lapses on the next world-motion.

Clock rule. A clock must have a named trigger and a named landing Truth. Keep no more than three important clocks in focus at once.

17 Fronts

A Front is an active source of pressure: **Name** · **Agenda** · **Standing Truth** · **Clock(s)** · **Levers** · **Seams** · **what it does if ignored** · **the Truth that lands when its clock fills**.

Fronts take no separate turns. They act through costs, setbacks, clock ticks, filled-clock Truths, compels, new opposition, and changed baselines.

In beat-by-beat conflict, after each full crew exchange, tick each active unaddressed pressure clock once — unless the crew spent action to stop, delay, redirect, or absorb it.

18 Preparation

Preparation happens in **Prep Rounds**. During a Prep Round each character takes one prep action — creating Truths, revealing clock states, establishing Access, creating Position or Leverage, discovering Seams, or reducing uncertainty — and at the round's end the relevant Front or mission Clock ticks once.

Information gained in prep *reveals* Ledger opportunities; it pays only once acted on or established as a Truth. Preparation reaches Top Exit only by removing all live uncertainty from a **Simple** obstacle; a **Complex** obstacle needs its source of complexity removed first.

19 Opposition

CLASS	HANDLING
Obstacle	resolved by TN, Exposure, Effect, Truths, and clocks
Minor opponent	no Scar track; situational success may remove, bypass, or rout it if fiction supports
Significant opponent	has Stress, a clock, Scar capacity, or Front structure; terminal removal requires a Seam
Front	acts through clocks, Truths, costs, and world motion

Opposition does not roll separately by default: a single player roll resolves the actor's intent and the opposition's immediate response. A significant opponent may be **worn down by a clock that, when filled, lands a Truth** — a blocked Access or a live Seam — rather than by depleting a health total. (Significant opposition is noted as: Skill · Exposure baseline · any Stress/clock/Scar capacity · Seam(s) · goal · what it does if ignored.)

Volatile

Volatile is a tag for unstable power — magic, experimental tech, psychic force, dangerous rituals, hazardous energies. Volatile actions have **minimum Exposure 1** and **cannot reach Top Exit** unless the volatility is removed from the fiction. Their consequences take this overlay:

RESULT OVERLAY

Triumph	succeeds with stepped-up Effect, but a tell, omen, or instability appears
Success	succeeds, but leaves a minor tell or unstable residue
Cost	succeeds; treat the Cost one Exposure tier higher — at Exposure 2, route the excess to a Scar via overflow or a live Seam instead
Setback	the situation turns hard; if a Seam is live, a Scar or major Truth may land

Define a Volatile power by **Source · Domain · Method · Cost · Limit · Tell**, never a fixed list.

Advancement

Mechanical growth comes only from **causal accomplishment** — things that happen through play, never from declared roleplay. Mark an advance when:

- you reach a **Top Exit** on a significant obstacle;
- a **Truth** you authored is **cashed by another character**;
- a **compel** genuinely costs you something;
- a **Held Truth** changes through play;
- a **Scar** **reshapes** how you play;
- a **significant Front or Clock** resolves through your action.

Spend marks for +1 **Skill** (cap 4; mastery 3→4 also requires a breakthrough written as a Truth) or a **new Trait or Bond**.

Table-conferred moments. At session's end, players name *each other's* standout moments; a conferred moment **deepens a Bond or evolves a Question** — never mechanical power.

22

Modes

A Mode is not a subsystem. It is a configuration of the same primitives — Roll, Ledger, Truth, Clock, Stress, Scar, Edge, Front — for a kind of conflict.

A Mode changes what the engine looks at, not what the engine is.

MODE	PRIMARY PRESSURE
Combat	Harm, ground, tempo, morale, Scars
Intrigue	Trace, reputation, leverage, access, Marks
Investigation	questions, clues, hidden Truths, time, false leads
Exploration	time, resource, hazard, route, environment
Politics	Fronts, legitimacy, coalition, public Truths
Magic	volatile power, cost, backlash, transformation

Mode rule. If a Mode seems to need a new core mechanic, first express it as TN, Exposure, Effect, Ledger, Truth, Clock, Stress, Scar, Edge, or Front. If it still needs a new resolution engine, reject it as subsystem growth.

23 Invariants

These define the engine. A rule that violates one is rejected.

1. TN measures task difficulty only.
2. Exposure measures consequence severity only.
3. Effect measures amount accomplished only.
4. The Ledger never changes TN.
5. Edge never creates Top Exit, and moves results only in band-space, never by die-total.
6. Top Exit is earned by fiction, never bought.
7. Bottom Exit is overcome by Access or a changed approach.
8. A Seam is required for terminal consequence against significant targets.
9. Scars land only by Stress overflow or Seam-enabled terminal consequence.
10. Truths persist until changed — standing Truths until play changes them, maintained Truths until world-motion erodes them; they inform baseline everywhere but pay Ledger only where they change baseline.
11. No roll produces nothing — and where nothing is at stake, there is no roll.
12. No post-roll renegotiation.
13. Dice never author player-character interiority.
14. Opposition acts through consequences, clocks, and Truths unless a module adds opposed rolling.
15. Preparation costs time.
16. Competence is reliable success; tension comes from Exposure, Effect limits, Clocks, Fronts, Seams, and world motion — never from whiffing.
17. Expression refreshes Edge; it never advances mechanical power. Advancement comes only from causal accomplishment.
18. Every mechanic must route through the core surfaces or be rejected as subsystem growth.

Establish: TN = task difficulty Exposure = severity Effect = amount
(default TN 10 · Exposure 1 · Effect Standard)

- Position → -1 Exposure
- Leverage → +1 Effect
- Access → Bottom Exit becomes a Live Roll
- Seam → terminal consequence becomes possible

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Exit Check: Bottom Exit → no roll, find Access.
Top Exit → no roll, narrate. (Simple only; Complex keeps the roll,
no live clock or Exposure → also a Top Exit)
Otherwise → roll 3d6 + Skill vs TN:
    Triumph (+3↑): intent + Effect step + 1 Edge
    Success (0..+2): intent
    Cost (-1/-2): intent + a cost at Exposure
    Setback (-3↓): intent fails + the situation worsens at Exposure
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Record: lasting change → Truth (standing, or maintained and eroding on world-motion).
 accumulating pressure → Clock. short-term pressure → Stress.
 overflow or live Seam → one Scar.

Edge: gain on Triumph, compel, or costly expression of a Truth;
spend to step a result up one band ($\leq$ once/roll); never touches dice or TN.

Advance: only on causal accomplishment. Expression buys agency, never power.

World: Fronts advance when ignored, triggered, or clocked; maintained advantages lapse unless renewed.

Return to the next live Intent.